

Loaded Cafe

Is it a coffee or a dessert? Either way, they're filming it.

What It Is

Loaded Cafe is a coffee concept that turns a standard drink into a high-margin spectacle: toasted marshmallows on top, hot chocolate poured inside, a scoop of ice cream, and a chocolate drizzle to finish. It's a simple product engineered into a viral brand asset — customers record it and share it, driving new traffic without spending a cent on ads.

How It Makes Money

You sell signature loaded drinks at \$7-\$11 from a kiosk, container, or small storefront, alongside a regular coffee menu. Customers are dessert-and-coffee lovers, students, families, and the social-media crowd. The theatrical build justifies premium pricing, and every customer's phone becomes a free ad channel. Add-ons (extra toppings, dessert pairings, branded merch) raise the average ticket.

Startup Costs

- Espresso machine + grinder: \$1,500-\$6,000 (used lowers this)
- Ice cream freezer + blender + torch: \$500-\$1,500
- Ingredients (coffee, chocolate, marshmallow, ice cream, toppings): \$400-\$1,000
- Kiosk/container or small space buildout: \$3,000-\$15,000
- Branded cups + photogenic packaging: \$300-\$900
- Permits, food license, commissary: \$300-\$1,500
- Branding and signage: \$400-\$1,500
- **Realistic start: \$6,000-\$22,000** (lower as a market pop-up first)

Sourcing: Buy cups, torches, and tools from Alibaba — search "commercial espresso machine," "double wall coffee cup custom print," and "kitchen butane torch." Source beans, chocolate, and ice cream from local wholesale for freshness.

The Numbers

- Cost per loaded drink (coffee, chocolate, marshmallow, ice cream, cup): ~\$1.80-\$3.20
- Sell price: \$7-\$11
- Profit per drink: ~\$4.50-\$7.50
- Slow day: 50 drinks → ~\$300 profit
- Strong day (viral pull + good spot): 180-260 → ~\$1,000-\$1,700 profit
- Monthly at a steady kiosk: \$9,000-\$18,000+ gross profit before rent/labor

How To Start

1. Perfect 2-3 signature loaded drinks that look incredible and build in under 2 minutes.
2. Add a normal espresso menu so you capture everyday coffee buyers too.
3. Set up a kiosk/container with strong lighting for filming the build.
4. Handle permits, food license, and commissary requirements.

5. Soft-launch at a market or busy corner; film the marshmallow torch and pour for every order.
6. Post the build daily on Reels/TikTok and tag your location.
7. Add seasonal loaded drinks and merch once regulars build up.

Where To Get Customers

- Instagram Reels and TikTok — the loaded build is the entire growth engine
- Local foodie / "aesthetic cafe" pages and micro-influencers
- Google Maps, Yelp, and "viral coffee near me" search
- High-foot-traffic placement (campus, mall, tourist district)
- Cross-promo with dessert spots and event organizers

Pro Tips

- Make the build a performance — torch the marshmallows at the counter where everyone can see and film it.
- Price the signature drinks like dessert, not coffee; customers anchor to a \$10 sundae, not a \$4 latte.
- Run a monthly limited drink to keep regulars coming back and refreshing your social feed for free.